

English

Stage 8

Paper 1 Non-fiction

2022

Cambridge Lower Secondary Progression Test

Insert



Text A

Mechanical performances?

Robots is as visually engaging as the best digitally animated films. The landscapes are really stunning, there's plenty of high-octane action, and actor-comedian Robin Williams provides plenty of laughs. Despite these positive qualities, it more often resembles a video game than a movie. It doesn't take long to uncover the culprit for *Robots*' lack of inspiration. The dreary plot is targeted squarely at five-year-olds.

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Unfortunately, when it comes to vocal performances, Robin Williams is the only actor worth mentioning. His co-stars read their lines, but don't do anything more than that. Williams brings life and energy to his role as Fender. Most of his dialogue sounds improvised – we're never quite sure what Williams' animated alter ego is going to say or do next.

The narrative is familiar fairy-tale stuff: a young robot sets off to pursue his dreams and ends up doing great deeds. The robot, who is named Rodney Copperbottom, leaves the sleepy suburb of Rivet Town for the metropolis of Robot City. In Robot City, he wants to seek out his hero, Bigweld. But, when he arrives, Rodney learns that Bigweld has ominously disappeared. With the help of his new friend, Fender, Rodney aims to find Bigweld and rescue the city from the clutches of an evil robot called Ratchet.

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If the plot doesn't grab you, the look of the film will. The directors have created a robot world to stir the imagination: each of the robots is unique, gaudy colours run riot, crazy contraptions abound. The wow factor is greater in *Robots* than in many other digitally animated films. However, that only partly compensates for the emptiness of the story, and the lifelessness of all of the characters apart from Fender.

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The movie is peppered with content guaranteed to guard against boredom – an action sequence pops up every five minutes. And, of course, there's the humour. Ninety per cent of this comes from Williams' performance.

If you have kids, there's little chance that you'll escape seeing this movie. But when you do go, you'll probably enjoy yourself. *Robots* is not one of those must-see animated digital movies that works as well for adults as for children. *Robots* is more than a load of spare parts, but there are some nuts and bolts missing.

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Text B

Computer beats human at Go

Players of the ancient Chinese board game, Go, have been stunned by the success of a program called AlphaGo. The computer program has defeated a human champion, marking a significant advance for the development of artificial intelligence (AI).

AlphaGo beat legendary player Lee Se-dol in Seoul, South Korea, with a 4–1 victory. This is the first time a Go program has won so decisively against such a highly ranked player. The program is partly self-taught, having played millions of games against itself. Not even the developers can explain how AlphaGo analyses the game position and picks its next move.

Computers have previously surpassed humans in other games. Those include chess, checkers and backgammon. But AlphaGo's success is considered the most significant yet, due to the complexity of Go. The game requires creative and strategic thinking. According to researchers there are more possible positions in Go than atoms in the universe.

Go originated in China more than 2500 years ago. Two players take turns by putting black or white stones on a 19-by-19 grid. Players win when they take control of the most territory on the board.

The rules are simple. But playing it is not. It is said to be probably the most sophisticated game invented by humans so far.

Martin Mueller, a computing science professor who has worked on Go programs for 30 years, said the new program 'is really a big step up from everything else we've seen. It's a very, very impressive piece of work.'

AlphaGo's developers say its learning strategy may someday let computers help solve real-world problems. Those could include making medical diagnoses and pursuing scientific research.

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